

UPSC Philosophy Optional Paper 1 Simulation

QUESTION PAPER | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 250

INSTRUCTIONS

1. The paper has two sections, A and B, and eight questions.
2. Question 1 and Question 5 are compulsory.
3. Answer three other questions, choosing at least one from each section.
4. Answer five questions in all. The marks carried by each subpart are indicated.

SECTION A - Western Philosophy

Q1 (COMPULSORY)

- (a) "Sensible things are those only which are immediately perceived by sense." Explain Berkeley's theory of knowledge with reference to the above statement. [10 marks]
- (b) "The Soul of Superman is Good." Critically examine the above statement in the light of logical positivism. [10 marks]
- (c) Distinguish descriptive from revisionary metaphysics, and explain why Strawson describes his own project as descriptive. [10 marks]
- (d) Distinguish between the transcendental and the transcendent in Kant, and explain why the distinction is indispensable to the Transcendental Dialectic. Discuss. [10 marks]
- (e) Establish the tenability of later Wittgenstein's notion of language as form of life. [10 marks]

Q2

- (a) "I never can catch myself at any time without perception, and never can observe anything but the perception." How does this statement by Hume problematize the philosophical notion of personal identity? How does Kant deal with this problem in his Critique of Pure Reason? [20 marks]
- (b) "Berkeley destroys Locke's resemblance thesis but not his distinction between primary and secondary qualities." Critically examine. [15 marks]
- (c) Discuss the linguistic theory of necessary propositions and assess whether it succeeds in reconciling empiricism with the necessity of logic and mathematics. (Answer in about 250 words.) [15 marks]

Q3

- (a) "Logical positivism failed by its own standards and changed philosophy anyway." Critically examine this assessment of the movement. (Answer in about 350 words.) [20 marks]
- (b) "No statement is immune to revision." How far can this claim be sustained in the case of logic? [15 marks]
- (c) Assess the view that Kant's phenomena-noumena distinction is an empty boundary that his own system cannot sustain. [15 marks]

Q4

- (a) "Quine and Strawson criticise empiricism, but they do not criticise it together." Discuss. [20 marks]
- (b) "No course of action could be determined by a rule, because every course of action can be made out to accord with the rule." Critically examine Wittgenstein's treatment of this paradox. [15 marks]
- (c) Is Aristotle's view of nature of identity in consonance with his metaphysical view of causes as processes? Discuss giving suitable examples. [15 marks]

SECTION B - Indian Philosophy

Q5 (COMPULSORY)

- (a) "Buddhist epistemology is not a shortened Nyaya list." Examine this claim with reference to the two means of valid knowledge and the exclusion theory of meaning. [10 marks]
- (b) Delineate the main points of difference between the theory of intrinsic validation (svatah pramanyavada) and theory of extrinsic validation (paratah pramanyavada) in classical Indian philosophy. [10 marks]
- (c) "In Visistadvaita philosophy, the relationship between God and the world is parallel to that between an individual self and its body." Critically discuss. [10 marks]
- (d) Explain the difference between Samprajnata Samadhi and Asamprajnata Samadhi. [10 marks]
- (e) Distinguish between many-sidedness (anekantavada), standpoint theory (nayavada) and conditional predication (syadvada). Why is the order of derivation philosophically significant? [10 marks]

Q6

- (a) "Ignorance of dependent origination is suffering while its knowledge is cessation of suffering." Present an account of Buddhist soteriology in the light of above statement. [20 marks]
- (b) "The doctrine of two truths is what separates emptiness from nihilism." Critically examine, with reference to the four-cornered analysis. [15 marks]
- (c) "A candidate who is never seen to be studying during the day time secures a high position in a competitive exam." How would the Bhatta Mimamsakas and the Naiyayikas explain the success of this candidate? Discuss. [15 marks]

Q7

- (a) Does the admission of Svayamprakasavada necessarily lead to the admission of Svatahpramanyavada? Discuss after the Naiyayikas, the Mimamsakas and the Advaita Vedantins. [20 marks]
- (b) 'The doctrine of Relativism of Jain Philosophy cannot be logically sustained without postulating 'Absolutism'.' Critically examine this view and give reasons in the favour of your answer. [15 marks]
- (c) Explain Citta and its modifications in the philosophy of Yoga. Why does Yoga philosophy prescribe cessation of modifications of Citta? Give reasons in support of your answer. [15 marks]

Q8

- (a) Compare the Buddhist and Jaina responses to the problem of change and permanence, and assess which secures the reality of the world at lower philosophical cost. [20 marks]
- (b) How do Naiyayikas respond to Carvaka's objections against inference (anumana) and establish inference as an independent means of knowledge? Critically discuss. [15 marks]
- (c) Which Samkhya proof for the existence of Prakrti actually shows that there can be only one Prakrti? Justify your answer. [15 marks]

END OF PAPER